

**American International School
in Abu Dhabi**



**Athletics & Activities
Student-Parent Handbook
2025/2026**

Dear AISA Parents & Student-Athletes,

Welcome to AISA Lions Athletics!

The Parent Athletic Handbook has been developed to give you a clear understanding of the policies, procedures, responsibilities and expectations involved with athletics at AISA.

AISA has a long and outstanding history of athletics, participating for roughly 30 years in ISAC (International Schools Activities Conference – Abu Dhabi), and now as an associate member of the EAC (Emirates Athletic Conference), NESAC (Near East Schools Activities Conference), and a full member of the Junior Emirates Athletics Council (JEAC). AISA prides itself on developing the whole child.

As we prepare for a new school year and another exciting year of athletic competition, I would ask you to take time to read this handbook. This handbook is designed to provide all the information needed to guide you through your child's season. Your understanding of policies and procedures will help ensure the athletic program runs smoothly.

I look forward to working with you and to sustaining and improving upon our results from last year. A strong partnership between parents and the athletic department is crucial for the development of the Athletics program. Together we can ensure that the Lions teams have an opportunity to compete and achieve, in highly competitive leagues in our region.

Thank you

Yours sincerely,

Luka Zischka

Athletics & Activities Director

Phone: 02 444 4333 ext. 2867

Email: lzischka@aisa.sch.ae

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Junior Varsity & Varsity Athletics Philosophy

The purpose of the Interscholastic Athletic Program at AISA is to promote the Physical, Mental, Moral, Social and Emotional wellbeing of the student. We aim to support the school values to foster a culture of Responsibility, Integrity and Respect in our whole AISA community. Participants in the program will be expected to display the proper ideals of sportsmanship, ethical conduct, and fair play; to show respect to opposing teams, fellow players, coaches, and all officials.

We believe athletic competition helps students to attain their full potential as unique, valuable individuals. AISA provides students with the opportunity to develop physical fitness, a sense of fair play, expose them to team work and a sense of belonging and common good. It is a constructive and positive use of leisure time.

Elementary & Middle School Athletics Philosophy

The AISA Elementary and Middle School Athletic program provides our student-athletes with the appropriate fundamental skills and support necessary to develop them for the next level of participation with the emphasis on FUN. It is our intent to provide as many sporting opportunities as possible for the students in grades 4-8. Our grade 4,5,6 teams play in the Junior Emirates Athletic Conference and our Middle School teams compete in the EAC league. There is greater focus on team play and competition in grades 6, 7, and 8.

Our philosophy is to engage as many students in the athletic and activities programs as possible, however it is recognized that in certain sports, teams in the Middle School will be selected based upon playing ability to create a manageable number of players for training purposes and competition.

We provide a 'no cuts' programs in Grades 4, 5 and 6 for boys' and girls' Soccer, Track & Field and Basketball ("CUBs") where every student that wishes to play is included regardless of ability.

It is acknowledged that 'playing time' is an important and sensitive issue amongst both athletes and parents, and we maintain a philosophy that grade 6-8 student-athletes should be given meaningful, though not necessarily equal, playing time in all regular season games. At this level, the enjoyment of playing the game is paramount; therefore, all students should play in every game. Coaches are instructed to plan effectively to allow all team members to play a 'meaningful' part. Not getting a player into a game at this level in regular season games is unacceptable.

Tournament play is significantly different due to the shorter length of games. Both parents and students must understand that it is possible that some students may not get 'playing time' in every tournament game; however, all players will be given the opportunity to play at some point within the tournament. It is unacceptable for grade 6-8 athletes not to play in the mid- season or end of season tournaments.

Objectives of the Athletic/Activities Program

To provide students with the opportunity to develop advanced and specialized athletic skills; to achieve a high level of fitness; and to increase their knowledge of game strategies, tactics, and rules.

To promote sportsmanship, stability, and meaningful social concepts through participation in athletics.

To help students learn to respect and value necessary and responsible authority.

To help students learn to accept criticism in the context in which it is given and use it as a tool for self-improvement.

To help students acquire an increased measure of self-discipline, as well as understanding its value in pursuit of certain clearly defined goals.

To field teams which are skilled, dedicated, disciplined, and motivated.

To develop a working atmosphere in which relationships between coach and athlete, and having pride in representing the school can be enhanced.

To always try to provide qualified coaches for all athletic activities.

To provide adequate equipment and facilities.

To provide a diverse program for AISA students.

What is NESAC?

NESAC is an acronym for Near East Schools Activities Conference. It is a premier athletics and activities conference in the region, founded in 2014. Our Junior Varsity and Varsity teams compete in NESAC. NESAC member schools run three, eight-week seasons in sports and activities. The eight-week season culminates in a NESAC championship tournament. These tournaments are hosted on a rotational basis among member schools.

We compete in the following NESAC tournaments with teams that are usually broken down into age brackets: Junior Varsity (Primarily Grades 9 -10) & Varsity (Primarily Grades 11-12):

- Volleyball
- Swimming
- Leadership Conference
- Academic Games
- Soccer/Football
- Basketball
- Band & Choir
- Badminton
- Track & Field

NESAC School members are:

American International School Kuwait (AISK)

American School Kuwait (ASK)

American Community School, Beirut (ACS)

International College, Beirut (IC)

GEMS American Academy, Abu Dhabi (GAA)

American International School in Abu Dhabi (AISA)

American School Dhahran (ASD)

**Dunecrest American Academy (DAS) (Associate Member)*

**College of Cairo (CAC) (Associate Member)*

UAE & Regional Athletic Competition

AISA organizes seasonal athletic exchanges with the following schools in the region as the part of the Emirates Athletic Conference (EAC):

EAC Schools:

American School of Dubai (ASD)
Dubai American Academy (DAA)
Universal American School, Dubai (UAS)
Gems American School of Abu Dhabi (GAA)
American Community School Abu Dhabi (ACS)
American International School Abu Dhabi (AISA)

Other Schools:

Canadian International School Abu Dhabi (CIS)
International Community School Abu Dhabi (ICS)

AISA competes in the following sports with other American International schools in the region.

- * Middle School, Junior Varsity & Varsity Volleyball
- * Middle School, Junior Varsity & Varsity Swimming
- * Junior Varsity/Varsity Golf
- * Middle School, Junior Varsity & Varsity Soccer
- * Middle School, Junior Varsity & Varsity Basketball
- * Middle School, Junior Varsity & Varsity Cross Country
- * Junior Varsity/Varsity Tennis
- * Junior Varsity & Varsity Badminton
- * Middle School, Junior Varsity, & Varsity Track & Field

In addition, our Junior teams compete in Junior Emirates Athletics Conference (JEAC) which provides some seasonal games and a jamboree style tournament day at the end of each season. This “no cuts everyone included” program is for boys and girls in 4th, 5th and 6th Grade levels.

We compete in the following JEAC Tournaments:

- Grade 4/5 and 6 Soccer – Season - 1
- Grade 4/5 and 6 Track & Field - Season 2
- Grade 4/5 and 6 Basketball – Season - 3

SEVEN KEY CHARACTERISTICS OF AN AISA COACH

CHARACTER he/she and acts in an ethical, honest, and trustworthy manner and displays and promotes a healthy lifestyle/environment

COMPETENT

He/she has a solid understanding of the rules, mechanics, and strategies of the sport being coached and is conversant with the policies and procedures contained in the AISA Coaches Handbook.

COMMITTED

He/she works hard and is committed to building a successful and competitive program

CARING

He/she genuinely cares about the players and their overall success

CONFIDENCE BUILDER

He/she is effective at building and maintaining players' confidence

COMMUNICATOR

He/she is an effective communicator and listener

CONSISTENT

He/she is consistent in terms of his/her mood and approach to team discipline

NESAC JV & VARSITY ELIGIBILITY

JV and Varsity Eligibility Rules are set by NESAC with further guidelines set by our school to support and align with our program philosophy.

- Junior Varsity for NESAC purposes is considered as Under 16 as of September 1st of the current school year and in Grade 8 –10. In order for a Grade 8 student to be selected to a JV team at AISA, they must be considered a ‘starter’ or first player off the bench. A Grade 8 student will not take a roster spot from a Grade 9 or Grade 10 student unless this is the case.
- Varsity for NESAC purposes is considered Grade 9 –12. In order for a Grade 10 student to be selected to a varsity team at AISA, they must be considered a ‘starter’ or ‘first player off the bench’. *(In order for a Grade 9 player to be selected to a Varsity team at AISA, they must be considered to be an exceptional player and the best player at their position. The Athletics/Activities Director must approve any Grade 9 & 10 students selected to a Varsity team.)*

SELECTION OF TEAMS

EAC and NESAC guidelines restrict the number of players permitted on a team. As a result, it is usually necessary to have tryouts and team selections. The approximate dates for tryouts are the first two or three sessions of the season. Specific dates, locations and other relevant information will be posted prior to tryouts on the Athletics page of the AISA website, as well as available online and the Channel/Lions News (student announcements) and the google classrooms set-up by the coaches.

Skill levels will be objectively assessed during tryouts. Coaches also consider factors such as attitude, leadership, spirit, etc. when evaluating candidates. Team selection will be posted promptly following the tryout sessions. **If an athlete is to be “cut” then the coach must have a face-to-face conversation with the student to explain the reasons why and discuss areas in need of improvement so that they might qualify for the team in the next season.** Alternatively, they are encouraged to become actively involved in another manner, perhaps as a manager, scorekeeper, or through participation in clubs.

A frequent point of discussion (at every level) is the declaration of the “travel team”. Typically, more athletes are eligible to be on the team and letter in a sport than can travel to NESAC tournaments. The NESAC squad is generally announced three to four weeks prior to the date of departure. It is a very difficult decision for the coaches to make (and is subject to change under some circumstances). To be left off the travel squad is difficult for a student that has worked hard for several weeks and some suggest it may be less cruel to cut them at the beginning of the season. Our feeling is that this way the student has been given fair time to develop and to prove their worth (rather than base that decision on only three tryout sessions) and, more importantly, they have received the benefit of a full season of practices and competitions which will be of great benefit to them the following year.

ROSTERS

Once a coach has selected their team the roster must be submitted to the Athletic Department, they will input the data to the necessary league. Any changes to rosters must be communicated to the athletic office immediately.

Your team roster, game schedule and practice schedule will be uploaded to the google classroom team page. Parents and student-athletes are included on the roster and receive regular updates.

WEEKLY SCHEDULE

Every Thursday the athletic director publishes the following week’s athletic game schedule via the AISA newsletter. Game schedules do change so please check the weekly schedule every week. Any changes will also be communicated via email (google classroom) to the parents, students and coaches.

ATHLETICS/ACTIVITIES CODE of CONDUCT and REQUIREMENTS

ATHLETIC CODE OF CONDUCT

Student-athletes and parents are required to complete and sign the AISA Athletic Code of Conduct.

MEDICAL PERMISSION FORM

Student-athletes and parents are required to complete and sign the Medical Permission Form.

LOYALTY TO THE TEAM

Because our programs involve team sports, each team member has an obligation to the team to abide by the rules and to play fair. What one player does affects everyone else on the team. Should a suspension occur, not only has the athlete let himself/herself down, but has let the team down as well.

ACADEMIC ELIGIBILITY

It is the student's responsibility to be in good standing with no academic or behavioral restriction.

STUDENT CONDUCT AND BEHAVIOR

Students are expected to conduct themselves at all times in a manner that positively represents them; their family, and the AISA school community. Good sportsmanship is paramount.

Behavior and or conduct that is not in the best interest of the school, which occurs within the activity setting and/or outside the parameters of the activity situation may constitute grounds for suspension or dismissal from the team, and/or future athletic teams and activities (see description). It may also have repercussions with regard to athletic awards depending on the seriousness of the offense.

Students must abide by all NESAC and EAC rules and regulations and the laws of the United Arab Emirates and the laws of the countries we visit.

ATTENDANCE

Attendance at practices and games is mandatory. A student must be present at a minimum of 85% of practices/games in order to be considered a member of the team and eligible for travel, tournament play, or any athletic awards. A student must be in attendance for a minimum of three class periods or two blocks on the day of the event/activity. Attendance is monitored by the HS and MS office and reported to the Athletic Director on game days and communicated to coaches. **Coaches and the Athletic Director may utilize training practices and playing time to incentivize attendance.**

Athletes should be made aware of the consequences of missing more practices than permitted during the season. The coach may see fit to modify the number of practices missed if there are exceptional circumstances and will inform the Athletic Director.

In addition it is mandatory that students be in school on days of games, trips and the day before and after an athletic trip / tournament. If a student doesn't attend school the day before a game he/she is not eligible. If he/she does not attend the day after a game, this may result in the student not being able to participate in the next practice or game.

If a student is planning to be away from school for two or three days for a NESAC tournament, they must fill out and submit a Planned Absence Form as early as possible, but no later than 24 hours prior to travel. These forms are available in the High School office. Students will not be allowed to travel for school trips unless this form is completed.

For teams returning late from NESAC tournaments/events, there is a 10 hours rule. For example; if a team arrives back at midnight then the students are permitted to miss the start of the day and report at 10am. If a team arrives later than midnight, then the student is permitted to miss the morning lessons and arrive during the lunch break. The coach must communicate this clearly to the team on arrival back in Abu Dhabi and must also text the Athletic Director, who in turn will inform the HS/MS office.

TEAM TRAVEL

All athletes are required to travel to and from out-of-town games with the team in school- arranged transport and be dressed in the AISA Team travel uniform as outlined by the Athletic Director. They are not allowed to be transported by a student driver. Permission to return home with their parents after an away game may be granted on an individual basis. For NESAC travel, student-athletes are required to travel wearing the school appropriate clothing as determined by the coaches, athletic director, or school administrators.

ELIGIBILITY AND TRAVEL POLICY

The following eligibility guidelines will be applied to all AISA extra-curricular activities.

1. A student will be considered eligible to participate during that reporting period if they are in “good standing”.
2. Class attendance is mandatory the day before and the day following any extracurricular activity. Participation in extracurricular activities is an additional responsibility that should not conflict with the student’s primary academic responsibilities.
3. Absences for school sponsored trips count toward the total absences for the semester. Only students who have completed a planned absence form are eligible to travel.
4. Students on Athletic/Activity trips are required to follow AISA Dress Code Guidelines at all times.
5. If a student has been recognized as a full team member of a sports team / activity and then quits or is released for disciplinary reasons he/she may not join another activity during that season.
6. To be eligible to travel students and at least one parent must attend the pre-trip travel meeting or make an appointment to meet with the Athletics/Activity Director. Students-Athletes are declared ineligible if in violation of the AISA Athletic Code.

RESPONSIBILITIES OF ATHLETES

- Attend **all** practices and games. If they are unable to attend a practice or game they must inform their coach in person unless they are absent from school.

- If an athlete does not fulfill the attendance requirements he/she may be ineligible to travel and or forfeit any awards related to that sport. Excused absences count against the total required.
- Be at practice and games on time and ready to play.
- Abide by the dress code outlined by the Athletic Director and travel on transport arranged by the school. Permission to return home with their parents after an out-of-town game may be granted on an individual basis.
- Athletes must conform to the AISA dress code. Wear acceptable practice uniform at practice, consisting of: shirt, shorts and the correct footwear.
- Show respect to their coach, their fellow team players, opponents, visiting coaches and all officials.
- Be prepared to help with games for other teams - table officials, line judges etc. Responsibly maintain and use equipment. They are to help ensure all equipment is returned after a practice or game including their uniform.
- Ensure they meet the AISA Academic requirements for eligibility to participate in an activity.
- Abide by all the laws of the United Arab Emirates and the laws of the countries we visit. An athlete who quits after being recognized as a team member may not join another activity until that season is over.

RESPONSIBILITIES OF THE PARENTS

- Work with school personnel to assure an appropriate academic as well as athletic/activity experience for your child while he/she attends AISA.
- One parent must attend the pre-travel meeting or make an appointment with the Athletics/Activity Director for their student to be eligible to travel.
- Assure your child will attend all scheduled practices and contests.
- Require your child to abide by the Athletic Department's training rules.
- Acknowledge the ultimate authority of the coach to determine strategy and player selection.
- Promote mature behavior from students and parents during contests.
- Work cooperatively with other parents and school personnel to assure a wholesome and successful program for our school.
- Conduct themselves as mature role models, supporting the team in a positive manner.
- Respect the decisions made by the game officials and tournament personnel.
- Display only sportsmanlike behavior.

- Treat visiting teams, parents, and fans with respect and when representing AISA at other schools do so in a manner that is positive.

DISCIPLINARY ACTION

Athletes are expected to conduct themselves at all times in a manner that positively represents themselves, their family, and the AISA school community. Behavior and/or conduct that is not in the best interest of the school, which occurs within or outside the athletic setting may constitute grounds for suspension or dismissal from the team.

Alcohol/Tobacco and Illegal Substances

The use or possession of alcohol, tobacco (including shisha and dokha and e-cigarettes (vaping)), and illegal substances by team members is prohibited. Any player found to be using or possessing these substances at any time during a season will be dismissed from the team immediately.

If the above rule is violated outside a school-sponsored event, but during a season, which a student is participating in, the following will apply:

- Removal from the roster
- Forfeiture of all awards associated with that sport.

Curfew

When students are participating in any NESAC event **the curfew is 10:00 p.m.** unless stated otherwise by the tournament director.

Students are expected to follow all rules of the NESAC and EAC Handbook.

If the above rules (Alcohol/Tobacco/Illegal Substances and/or Curfew) are violated during a NESAC/EAC event, and the offense is such that a player is dismissed from the team the player will:

- Forfeit all awards associated with that sport.
- Forfeit the right to reimbursement of trip expenses.
- Be sent home early from the event, if possible, with any additional costs incurred by the parents.
- Be ineligible to participate in any NESAC/EAC activity for a period of 12 months.
- Be ineligible to be nominated for any Individual AISA Athletic Award.
- Be referred to the School Counselor to discuss the matter.

UNIFORMS

Team uniforms are issued to each team member and are the responsibility of the student- athlete.

Care – It is important that AISA teams are well presented and, for example, if the white has become grey the presentation is poor. Additionally, if uniforms are dirty or not washed regularly then presentation is poor. Please take care when washing uniforms. Wash in cold water, hang to dry and do not wash with other clothes that may affect the color. The coach may decide to collect all uniforms and wash them at the school.

Team Appearance – Team uniforms will only be worn during competition. Team uniforms are not to be used for practices. All AISA teams must look like a team while representing AISA! Non-uniform clothing is not permitted.

Return – Uniforms are collected after the last game of the season and returned to the school by the coach. If the uniform is not collected, please ensure that it is washed and returned to the coach within one week of the end of the season. The athletic office keeps records of uniform numbers. Students will be financially responsible for uniforms not returned.

AISA Communication Expectations for Coaches/Sponsors, Athletes, and Parents

Parenting and coaching are extremely difficult vocations. Our goal is to establish quality communication between our parents, athletes and coaches.

The following information was designed to clearly outline expectations that AISA parents, athletes and coaches must be aware of in order for our athletic/activities programs to be successful.

Parents and Athletes should expect the following from AISA Coaches and the Athletic Department;

1. Timely communication from the athletic department with regard to athletic game schedules and tournament information. Please check the weekly schedule, which is published in the AISA Newsletter every Thursday.
2. The coaching staff act as a role model for good sportsmanship, use of appropriate language, professional appearance, promotion of a healthy environment, and safe teaching/coaching techniques.
3. All information regarding team requirements, fees, special equipment, off-season opportunities, transportation arrangements and location and time of all practices.
4. AISA, NESAC, and EAC eligibility requirements.
5. Well-planned practices.
6. Award requirements.

Coaches should expect the following from Parents:

1. Complete support of the AISA Athletic Code of Conduct and all team regulations.
2. Positive support for their child, all coaches and other team members at all times.
3. Good sportsmanship exhibited toward officials, players and coaches at all times.
4. Notification to coaches of any schedule conflicts that may occur well in advance (**vacations**). If it is a cut sport these conflicts should be shared before tryouts.
5. Encourage your child, if they have a concern, to speak directly to their coach.

Coaches should expect the following from Athletes:

1. Complete commitment to the TEAM during the school year sport season.
2. Great work ethic at all times.
3. Exhibition of good sportsmanship and appropriate language at all times.

Recommended Procedure for Addressing a Concern with a Coach:

Step 1: Athlete seeks out his/her coach to discuss concern (*Parents please speak with your child about the concern and encourage your son/daughter to speak with their coach*).

Step 2: Parent requests conference with the coach or coaching staff.

(Please call during school hours and leave a message for the coach either on his/her voice mail or with the Activities Office).

Step 3: If the conference between the athlete and coach, or parent, athlete and coach does not resolve the concern, a meeting will be set up with the Director of Athletics/Activities. The Director of Athletics/Activities will mediate the conference.

Appropriate Concerns that a Parent may address with the Coaching Staff:

1. The treatment of your child mentally and physically.
2. Ways that your child can improve his/her performance and skill level.
3. Concerns about your child's behavior in school, practice or contests.
4. The make up of the team in relation to your child.
5. Coaches will not discuss other team members, other parents, or other members of the AISA coaching staff.
6. Coaches will not meet with a parent immediately after a contest. Parents must wait until the next school day and refer to the recommended procedure for addressing a concern with a coach.

ATHLETIC AWARDS

The following awards are the only awards to be given by the coach at the Athletic Award Ceremony.

At the end of the season the coach(es) of the team will select one athlete from their team for the following awards.

Criteria

1. Start and finish the season on a JV or Varsity team, i.e. make all cuts and remain academically eligible.
2. Participate in a minimum of 85% of all scheduled practices. Compete / attend 85% of all team games. It is the prerogative of the individual coach to modify these criteria if agreed to by the Athletic Director and the athletes are to be informed at the start of the season
3. It is not required that an athlete be a member of the NESAC Team in order to earn an Athletic award. However, they must have completed the season as a team member.
4. Any students who has been suspended from a team due Athletic Code violations is ineligible for any team award and is ineligible to be nominated for any AISA Individual Athletic Award.

TEAM AWARDS

The following awards are the only awards to be given by the coach at the Athletic Award Ceremony.

At the end of the season the coach(es) of the team will select one athlete from their team for the following awards.

1. **Most Valuable Player / Athlete / Runner / Swimmer (MVP)** is an honor typically bestowed upon the best-performing student-athlete. This is the team member who, in the judgment of the coach (es) best meets the following criteria:

- Consistently performs at a high level of performance.
- Is the player most responsible for the team's success.
- Demonstrates leadership qualities and excellent team spirit.
- Consistently shows a positive attitude and enthusiastic approach.
- Has excellent attendance at practices and games. (above 85%)

2. **Most Improved Player / Athlete / Runner / Swimmer (MIP)**

This is the student-athlete who, in the opinion of the coach (es), best meets the following criteria:

- Shows the most improvement over the duration of the season.
- Demonstrates a willingness to learn and grow as a player and is very "coachable".
- Demonstrates determination, perseverance and consistently works hard during training and games.
- Consistently shows a positive attitude and contributes enthusiastically to team spirit.
- Has excellent attendance at practices and games. (above 85%)

3. **Coaches Award** – This student-athlete may not necessarily be the best player but the athlete the coach(es) feel contributed the most to the team and its development/success. The coach sets the criteria.

END OF YEAR INDIVIDUAL AWARDS

Junior Varsity & Varsity - Athlete of the Year

This award is given to a male and female athlete who competed on any of the JV athletic teams for the year. The criteria for this award are:

- In any grade level.
- Positive team leadership.
- Contributes significantly to the team's success.
- Represents our school positively to our community and others on and off the court/field.
- Wins with honor, loses with dignity

Senior Scholar Athlete Award

This award is presented to one senior. The criteria for this award are;

- Competed on at least two varsity athletic teams in their senior year.
- Has at least a 3.25 GPA for the first 3 quarters of their senior year.
- Represent our school positively to our community and others on and off the Court/field.

IMPORTANT NUMBERS

Luka Zischka – Athletics/Activities Director

Office: 02 444 4333 ext.2867

Nurses Office: 02 444 4333 ext.2835

Maintenance Office: 02 444 4333 ext.2826